odd man out at the London conference over reintegration.'[71] As the *Times of India* stated, despite 'being the biggest regional aid-giver to Afghanistan with a commitment of $1.3 billion ... Turkey, an ally of Pakistan, did not even bother to invite India to a confabulation on Afghanistan'.[72]

Top Indian strategist K. Subrahmanyam called the London conference and Pakistan's role therein as 'the second deception'.[73] Widely portrayed as a 'victory for Pakistan' and a 'setback' for New Delhi by the Indian press, the conference was accompanied by a crackdown by the Pakistan army on the leadership of the Quetta *shura* and detention of 124 Taliban militants, whose existence Pakistan had denied throughout.[74] The suddenness of Pakistan's crackdown and appreciation of the same by the US persuaded India's 'strategic community that the Obama administration has decided to make use of the services of Pakistan to partly neutralise and partly buy up the Afghan Taliban and leave Afghanistan at the mercy of Pakistan in 2011, when the American forces plan to withdraw from Afghanistan'.[75] Adding credibility to India's concerns were official US assessments of the threat emanating from Pakistan. In February 2009, then Director of National Intelligence (DNI) Dennis Blair had informed the Senate Intelligence Committee that Islamabad was convinced that militant groups are an important part of its strategic arsenal to counter India.[76] Blair asserted that Islamabad maintained relationships with other Taliban-associated groups including the Haqqani Network, the Gul Bahadur group and the Commander Nazir group that conducted operations against the US and ISAF forces in Afghanistan.[77] Though these reports adversely impacted US-Pakistan relations (which became worse in May 2011 when Washington carried out the Abbottabad raid against Osama bin Laden), Indian perceptions about the West's desire to cut its losses in Afghanistan persisted. Katju, a key partisan (but no more part of the policymaking setup) lamented that 'such is the measure of America's strategic desperation that it has accepted the Taliban's vague assurances and gone to great lengths to accommodate the outfit.'[78]

Why was India averse to the Western forces negotiating with the Afghan Taliban if it had developed a nuanced understanding of the movement? There are two aspects to this puzzle. Firstly, the conference occurred at a critical juncture in India's bureaucratic shuffle. Narayanan, a partisan, retired as NSA in January